Thank you for the opportunity to submit this report of the experiences of the people of the Electorate of Forrest at the May 2025 Federal Election. Our submission will take the form of extracts from personal experiences of volunteers and voters alike. We called upon people within our community to volunteer this information and the response was significant. At the end of each response, we have included the initials of the person who wrote it and the Term of Reference (TOR) it relates to. We have names and contact details if required. For the purposes of this submission, we have numbered the Terms of Reference (TOR) as follows:

1. assessment and review of the purported increase in incidents of aggressive conduct, deliberate obstruction, and intimidating behaviour towards voters, political participants, volunteers, and Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) officials;
2. potential reform of safety and security arrangements, including consideration of the powers, processes, and capacity of the AEC to manage and address increasingly threatening or disruptive behaviour;
3. the suitability and potential reform of measures to ensure universal voter access, including polling booth availability and location, early voting, remote polling, and postal voting arrangements; and
4. the suitability of the current authorisation framework and requirements, having regard to the evolution of communication methods and technology.
5. the implementation and operation of the electoral reform passed by the 47th Parliament, particularly regarding the use of money or capital in the most recent election;
6. reforms to address the ongoing threats of interference in our electoral system, both foreign and domestic; and
7. the composition of the Parliament as a whole, including: the length of the parliamentary term; the potential for fixed terms; and the number of elected representatives relative to the growth in population and the electorate.

Introduction:

We are grateful for the fact that Australia has compulsory preferential voting and the AEC as the independent facilitator and adjudicator of the process. However the following experiences all show that the campaign and polling period of 2025 has brought to light potential risks to our democratic processes and significant risks to the likelihood of diversity of political aspirants and community engagement.

An interesting experience I had at Australind during early voting wasn't something that could be reported but I thought you may be interested. We had a farm in Boyup Brook and K still helps our son on the property. At Australind there was a very vocal fellow wearing a "Keep the Sheep" shirt. Quite innocently I asked him where his farm was. "Oh I don't have a farm, I live in the city, but my Grandmother grew up on a farm and it is in my blood!!" He didn't bother to ask of my whereabouts… At Treendale on Election Day there were an incredible number of folks for the [redacted] Party handing out [redacted] How to Vote cards, Keep the Sheep, Save the Bay etc but I don't think any were from Forrest. The lady standing next to me was from Cunderdin.

J.S. TOR 6

I experienced abuse during my volunteering polling. I polled outside the sea scouts on the Thursday 24 April 2025 8am to 10am and Saturday 26 April 2025 8am to 10am. On the Saturday a blonde piggy tailed lady from [redacted] came directly up to me whilst I was alone on the footpath. The lady attacked why I was volunteering for [redacted] and how bad that was and continued to go on. As it is a later date, I cannot remember the exact conversation. However I was shocked at the personal attack, it was unprovoked and caused me considerable stress. Shocked that it was like the school bully yard tactics to prevent freedom of choice. I was rescued by one of [redacted] organisers. On the Thursday one of [redacted] signs fell down and a female [redacted] party volunteer came and put their sign directly in front of [redacted] sign. The Lady also took it on herself to direct people into parking bays which was not necessary. These types of behaviours could easily get worse and lead to violence. I would suggest there are people to police a code of conduct of behaviour for polling days. Should require further information please let me know. I am sorry did not record more detail.

F.C. TOR 1, 2

This is the **incident above** as told by the volunteer who came to the assistance of F.C.

On the morning of 26th April, Independent Candidate volunteer F.C was confronted by an abusive [redacted] Party person. From a distance, I noticed something was not right and walked up to where they were standing. The said abuser appeared to be in a heightened state of anger and I asked F.C if she was ok. She was calm, however somewhat taken aback at whatever had occurred. I was also subjected to a somewhat irrational tirade. I believe it had much to do with another supporter who had posted unpleasant criticism of [redacted] on Facebook. It seems that said abuser had a bone to pick with me over the recent follow up action to manage the other supporter, whose Facebook post was subsequently taken down. F.C told me that she was feeling bullied. Having endeavoured to advise said abuser that she was out of line, I took the decision to report her behaviour to the AEC Booth Supervisor, [redacted] It appeared to me from [redacted] initial reaction that said abuser may 'have form' in this regard. Whatever the case, I understand that [redacted] spoke with her.

B.K. TOR 1

Further to the **incident above**, there is more to add about the behaviour of the abusive [redacted] Party person.

On this same morning this same abusive [redacted] Party person came up to me and my fellow [redacted] volunteers and began showing us this unpleasant criticism spoken of above. She was asking us questions like, “Is this the person you want to support?” I knew that what she was doing was classic ‘gaslighting’ and ‘white anting.’ She was attempting to cast doubt in the minds of [redacted] supporters and it really was bullying and intimidation. She also referred to something else that had been posted on Facebook, by a person at another pre-polling

booth she frequented, about her behaviour. She exclaimed that she was going to get lawyers involved and so forth. She was full of aggression and bluster and was out to intimidate.

J.K. TOR 1

This year, I decided, after about 25 years of increasing disappointment with our party politics system of government, to look elsewhere to place my vote. The idea of an [redacted] best suited what I was looking for. Hence my choice to wear your shirt at the Margaret River High School voting booth. The polling booth had a constant stream of voters coming through.
I can't say to you that I was intimidated , accosted or abused to the point where I wouldn't do it again, however, I did receive comments like "what are you doing in that shirt?", "what about the sheep?", "Why are you wasting your vote?". This sort of banter I could pass off as sarcastic banter but it would not have been heard when people respected each other more 30 plus years ago. I can say, and this is probably more to the point, that there was a group of people pushing fairly hard for the [redacted] Party. They were not obnoxious, but they were obvious. At the time I did not know who they were. When I mentioned it to folks later and found out who they were, I did think that was a more than a "bit on the nose".
C.O. TOR 1, 6

My experience in the voting circus was standing in a queue for over half an hour, with a venous leg ulcer certainly was not ideal for me. When I did finally get inside there was more standing and waiting until eventually a staff member came and recognised my distress and got me a chair. In summing up, the whole thing took over an hour to fill out two forms and place them in their respective boxes. My experience is nowhere as bad as some stories I heard.
P.C. TOR 3

I was disgusted at the way Keep the Sheep was weaponised at the Sea Scout pre-polling booth and, as an ex-sheep farmer, gave a short history lesson on the demise of the sheep/wool industry to the young man holding up a sign. Noted that the next day there was not a representative whilst I was there. My experience at the Withers booth on election day was mystifying at first then alarming, when I twigged who the people were that were handing out how to vote material for the [redacted]. Their booth captain was confronting to voters and when a distressed woman came to me, I called him out. The fellow with whom I was conversing, a man of my vintage, made a call on his mobile and the booth captain vanished. He left behind his corflutes etc from his vehicle, not to be seen again. By this stage I had established one member was from Ongerup (car number plate) and me, being a country lad, know farming families from the district. He knew none of the families I mentioned, which intrigued me as they are well known families and he was unable to say why was he in Bunbury. I established that the fellow I shared a spot with is a company director from Perth's dealing in medical supplies, who had travelled up from Busselton. Oh, whereabouts do you live in Busselton I said thinking we may know people in common. Gave me an answer along the lines of sort of near the town centre on the way out of town but eventually said that he really lived in Perth but had an association with the area because of his business that he was a director of. As I tend to be a trusting person, it was not until after I heard about the Brethren's

involvement at the booths that it all made sense. I note that 4 Corners is doing a program on them this Monday. I am really alarmed that [redacted] Party feels it's ok to blatantly stack the polling stations with non-voting proxies. I am annoyed with the Keep the Sheep but understand the politics behind it.

T.L. TOR 1,2,6

1. Cap limits on all candidates spending, including spouse and support groups
2. Have all press releases fact checked to take out political smoke factor
3. Abolish 2 party preferred and keep preferential voting system so voters can vote for whomever they choose
4. Go to fix term elections to take out wow factor

R.G. TOR 5,6,7

The [redacted] Party always have many volunteers handing out how to vote information. They dominate the space allocated to do this and by sheer numbers. This can make myself and those handing out information for other party's feel quite intimidated. They also often are quite aloof & standoffish. This last election was held during the Margaret River Writers Festival & an International Writer was talking at the library. She looked quite scared as her escorts formed a circle around her and pushed past the "cult" brethren from Albany. Why were the Brethren Cult members handing out how to vote information when they do not actually vote themselves? I would like to see no more than say three representatives for each candidate at any one time. Any more allows domination of the space allocated. The political candidates should be held responsible for this threatening behaviour and apologise to the electorate.

J.B. TOR 1,2,6

The massive, nihilistic, untrue, and cruel attacks on the Forrest [redacted] candidate shattered me; I cannot think how much it must have hurt. For some time after polling day I remained emotionally exhausted, determined *never again* to go through the same experience. Time heals, but I remain wary. Clearly, this is intimidation, not conducive to effective democracy. The Brethren were very active at pre-poll stations in Busselton and Eagle Bay. Their tactic was to swamp incoming voters as they left their cars, obstructing any other parties from handing out How to Vote cards by an aggressive attitude and force of numbers. At each station that we manned, Brethren outnumbered other parties' teams by 2-3 to one. At the Eagle Bay pre-poll, the Brethren had set up a barbecue station at the entrance to the hall, offering [redacted] sausages to voters on the way in. Further, they went into the hall, crossing the no-go line, and took food to the polling officials. Is this not in contravention of polling station rules? I also witnessed a personal attack on one of the [redacted] volunteers who was loudly berated for swapping sides from [redacted] to by a [redacted] party worker, who became irate and abusive when checked by an supporter. Nasty and very unpleasant.

At a Meet the Candidates event in Busselton, we saw an early sign of how nasty this campaign would be. The viciousness of the heckling from some City Councillors and their supporters

was appalling. This unpleasant and hurtful theme is evident once again in the current Council elections. How do we stop blatant lies from being spread? Once again, democracy is the loser. I hope this is of use. I am happy to make a verbal presentation if that helps.
A.H. TOR 1,2,6

I have not volunteered to help in an election prior to 2025, and I found it to be a very ugly experience. The posters that were put out by the [redacted] party did not promote their policies but rather maligned [redacted] with inaccurate attacks. Arriving at the Busselton pre-polling booth on my first day was extremely intimidating. One local Busselton [redacted] supporter and five young people dressed in [redacted] gear from the wheatbelt were aggressively pushing their way forward to hand out [redacted] how to vote pamphlets. "Make Australia great again" and "we'll get rid of the gays" were some of the comments I heard. All the other parties represented were overwhelmed by these visitors to our electorate as well. They were happy to promote lies about [redacted] and, when questioned, knew nothing of her policies. I was told their accommodation was provided and so was their food. At the Eagle Bay polling booth the Plymouth Brethren were provided with a barbecue, rolls and sausages and bowls of sweets. They offered food to the voters passing by and took lunch in to the electoral officers.
B.H. TOR 1, 6

I have to say I was disgusted at the arrogance of the [redacted] Party bringing in the wacky Church Group (Plymouth Brethren) to support their campaign, they were not representative of our electorate or supporting any forward-looking ideals. I was also disappointed at the dirty tactics and negative smear campaign they undertook against other candidates. These seem to now be becoming standard practice here and in America and is definitely not democratic in my mind and definitely not where Australia should be going.
B.B. TOR 6

The following is an edited extract from an individual submission made by a volunteer. It has been used as part of this group submission as it is in keeping with the overall experiences of Forrest volunteers who were dissatisfied with the tactics used in the campaign and at polling booths. It also makes suggestions that reflect the general nature of the changes required for improvement of the electoral process.

We think that the number of volunteers and signs (not just ours) at pre-poll was excessive and annoying to voters. We were appalled at the pre-poll ambush of signs and leaflets denigrating the [redacted] candidate when there are no effective means of rebuttal and no ability to deal with truth in advertising issues.

Here are a few suggestions for consideration based on our experience:

- The period for pre-poll voting should be cut to one week. One week should provide sufficient opportunity for anyone who can't make polling day to cast a vote. If not, they can apply for a postal vote.
- The current period is exhausting for volunteers and favours those candidates who can field the greatest number of volunteers.

- Polling places should be for voting not campaigning
- Limit the amount and type of political advertising at polling places
- Limit candidate volunteer numbers at polling places
- Polling places should be primarily for people to cast their votes as they choose: not for campaigning. The potential for antagonism and conflict at polling places is exacerbated by campaigning by lobby and third-party groups: especially those that are not campaigning for a candidate but are campaigning against a candidate. Their derogatory sign's and leaflets will almost certainly be regarded as false or misleading by, at least, the targeted candidate's supporters. This promotes hostility and division which should be avoided generally, and particularly at a polling place.
- Voters should not have to run the gauntlet of multiple campaign volunteers working for the same candidate. The number of volunteers for each candidate should be limited to two or three per entrance to the polling place. This would allow for one volunteer on each side of an entrance and perhaps one to back up and co-ordinate. It would also be fairer to candidates with limited resources.
- The number of political advertising signs at polling places has become excessive and wasteful. Most are thrown out as rubbish after an election.
- Political advertising signs at polling places should be limited in size and number. Three or four per entrance per candidate is sufficient and there should be no other signs placed within 100 metres of the entrance.
- Only advertising signs that are authorised by a candidate's representative should be permitted. Signs authorised by lobby groups or third parties should not be permitted within 100 metres of the polling place. The purpose of the advertising signs should be to make clear to voters which candidate belongs to which party, or is an independent, to facilitate them making an informed vote.
- Advertising signs and leaflets that are derogatory to particular candidates, or advise voters not to vote for particular candidates, should not be permitted within 100 metres of polling places. It is easy to provide voters at polling places with false or misleading information which may affect the way they vote, but it is impossible for a targeted candidate to respond effectively.
- Volunteers should only be permitted to hand out voting cards and policy information for the candidate they represent, and should not be permitted to hand out material from lobby groups and third parties.
- Given the ease with which false information can now be created and disseminated, and how difficult it is to detect fakes, it should be a criminal offence to: manipulate or distort images of a candidate; attribute words, actions or specific policies to a candidate without evidence that the attributions are true.
- The Australian Electoral Commission should be empowered to require advertisements breaching these requirements to be removed in real time and for the offender to be required to issue corrections of equal prominence and duration to the offending advertisements.
- Further, in the event of a close election result, the use of demonstrably false or misleading advertising by the winning candidate should be a matter that can be

considered by a Court of Disputed Returns in deciding whether the election should be overturned. These requirements can only apply to matters of fact and not to matters of opinion.

- In reference to Party initiated applications for postal votes, when political parties or candidates send electors applications for postal votes, it should be a requirement that the envelopes for the completed applications are addressed to the Australian Electoral Commission; not to representatives of a party or candidate who can then access the elector's personal details for political advantage

G.B TOR 1-6

First, I found the many aggressive "Keep the Sheep" posters and the posters portraying nasty photos of the [redacted] Candidate very confronting and upsetting. No one should have to experience that treatment themselves. Neither do I think I should have had to stand in the vicinity of such unpleasantness whist going about my tasks as a pre-poll volunteer at the Sea Scouts Hall at Cobblestone Drive and at Dalyellup High School on election day. What example is it to younger generations to whom we should be demonstrating good values and respect?

Also, whilst on a stint at Cobblestone Drive, two [redacted] representatives next to me became very aggressive over the fact that one thought the other was not making sufficient effort. They began swearing at each other, and one pushed the other before he stormed off.

A.H. TOR 1

On the day of the election my companion and I were assisting at the Carey Park Polling Booth and made note of some men, claiming to be there for [redacted]. However, the local [redacted] coalition volunteers said they did not know them and separated themselves from them. These men were all dressed in jeans, blue stockman shirts, and boots. The behaviour by some of these men appeared to cause voters a level of discomfort. We surmised that they were from the Brethren or from outside of the Bunbury Forrest constituency. Apparently, Albany.

S.M. TOR 6

In the 2025 Federal election I volunteered for [redacted] who ran as an [redacted] in the electorate of Forrest. I volunteered to hand out how to vote cards at the pre-polling booth located at the Margaret River TAFE site. I attended every day. I was also booth captain at the booth at Rapids Landing Primary School on election day. My submission pertains to volunteers for the [redacted] Party during pre-polling. During pre-polling I was introduced to three volunteers who lived in Margaret River: [redacted] who mans a central pedestrian crossing during school times and is well known in the community; [redacted] a Social Science teacher at the High School and [redacted] a retired matron from the hospital.

I also met a number of volunteers who did not live in the electorate: [redacted] and [redacted] husband and wife, their daughter and another young woman who was introduced as a daughter of

their friend. This group explained that they were from Perth, and the daughter told me her father was a close friend of the [redacted] candidate, [redacted]. Like me, they also attended every day except for a day or two when [redacted] had to attend to business in Perth. [redacted] told me they had booked an Air B and B to stay in. In the first few days, meals and refreshments were delivered to them. On one occasion I asked [redacted] about posters that were displayed that had an unpleasant photo of [redacted] and a headline 'Keep the Sheep.' I said that the poster was unfair and I used the word lied, ie the poster lied. [redacted] was visibly upset by our conversation, left the area, and went to speak with [redacted] At the first opportunity I apologised to [redacted] He explained that they were Christians and the worst thing you could do is to accuse someone of lying. I apologised again and explained the posters misrepresented [redacted] position as set out on her website. He said that they knew [redacted] lied on her website. We left the conversation there.

As people they were friendly and, due to chatting with them, I established that their daughter and son attended a school in Willetton, a suburb of Perth, and was most likely OneSchool Global, the school run by the Plymouth Brethren. [redacted] became very defensive when I probed further. [redacted] was particularly determined to interact with voters as they waited in the queue and I often overheard her telling people that if the [redacted] Party was voted in they would establish an inheritance tax. I would describe some of her approach to voters as aggressive.

Another couple attended pre-polling on a number of days. The wife was pregnant and she looked very uncomfortable being at pre-polling. The husband explained that he ran a business erecting sheds with his three brothers. They were either from Gnowangerup or Dalwallinu.

There were other volunteers for the [redacted] Party who did not live in the electorate and, from how they interacted with the other volunteers from outside the electorate, I sensed they knew each other. One man was a very big man, loud and very intimidating. This group of volunteers was very different from the local [redacted] volunteers. The atmosphere at pre-polling was often tense and the presence of the volunteers from outside of the electorate created enormous conflict.

A central issue was the number of [redacted] volunteers at the booth. I think at times there may have been 10 [redacted] volunteers. This meant that we asked more [redacted] volunteers to attend. So many volunteers must have intimidated voters. By contrast the booth at Rapids Landing PS was manned by volunteers who lived locally. The atmosphere was collegial and supportive and the focus was on ensuring all voters felt comfortable and safe. **S.H. TOR 1,2,3,6**

Below are points I'd like to make:

- My experience with members of Plymouth Brethren at Australind pre-polling booth. There were 2 couples there every day, wearing [redacted] T-shirts. One guy was very pushy and took up a position at the entrance to the path leading in. His wife was always close by but less assertive. Once the AEC officer had to tell him to get back from

a car that was dropping off a disabled/ elderly person. The other couple took up positions in the carpark. I spoke to that guy. He told me he lived in Albany and had a farm equipment business there. I asked him why they were not campaigning in the O'Connor electorate. He said "We have plenty of others down there." He told me that he would not be voting so I asked why they were helping. He said the [redacted] were better for business. Once I saw an older man in a car coming by to check up on the four Plymouth Brethren volunteers. I would like to know who he was and what his role was in coordinating their work for the [redacted] party.

- There were far too many volunteers at the Australind pre-poll centre and at Parkfield PS booth on election day. Voters had to "run the gauntlet" to get inside. I noticed that many voters (I'd estimate more than 50%) did not want a How To Vote card and were looking at their phones as they walked in, which I gather meant they had used an online app to guide their voting. I would recommend that each candidate be allowed no more than two volunteers at each booth. Also, it would be better if the volunteers were not allowed to approach voters but were only there in an advisory capacity if voters requested help/information.
- Just before pre-polling opened I received a pamphlet from [redacted] in my mailbox. I found it offensive & full of derogatory photos & assertions about [redacted]. When I read it closely, the main misleading message he was giving about [redacted] was that she was really a [redacted] candidate in disguise. Unfortunately, I didn't keep it and I can't recall all the content. I would also like to be able to check who authorised it and how it was paid for.
- I found a lot of the corflute material at the booths really offensive, particularly that by the Keep the Sheep organisation.
- I'm concerned about the potential threat of interference in our elections by vested interests - both domestic and foreign. I believe the main driver behind the Keep the Sheep campaign is a trucking company, which is employed in transport of farm stock. Their personal attacks on [redacted] character and policies were untrue & offensive. The business interests of key Plymouth Brethren members also concern me. What are their motives? Who is funding their involvement in the elections? What do they hope to gain by influencing the outcome of the election?

W.A. TOR 1-6

My last active involvement in politics was as a student protesting against the Vietnam War, so I have a lot to learn about Australian politics. Current interest was kindled by my alarm at the apparent rise of the far-right political movements worldwide, but particularly in the US. This has prompted me to take a far more active interest, in the interest of future generations in this country. I watched the Four Corners program and the experiences in the eastern states appeared very similar to the situation I experienced here. What has happened to the principles of separation of church and state and the neutrality of the polling places? Is this a thing of the past? With this in mind, I would like to share a few observations.

At the polling places, I was expecting to see signage that was aimed at giving voters basic

information on the candidates and their political affiliations and inviting voters to Vote One for their candidate. I was appalled by the totally unacceptable and hateful signage that adorned the polling places I was involved with. I was pleased to see that quite a few voters called this out by confronting the [redacted] Party (Brethren) people directly. I would like to see all signage strictly controlled within the polling precincts. There is no place for childish, hateful and manipulative tactics. Personally, I was worried, as I sought to answer voters queries (especially about the lack of preferences on the Independent's How to Vote card), that I did not cross the line where I could be considered to be actively directing a vote.

The presence of the Plymouth Brethren was astonishing. The friendly aggressive approach I encountered from a family of women was disconcerting. The constant greetings and the using of my name every time I went near them, was both insincere and weird. I felt that they had been well-schooled in the best approach to counter you and your supporters. They had come from the Mount Barker region and claimed to be passionate about politics, which was odd considering they apparently do not vote due to religious beliefs. On one occasion I had to ask one of these women to back off when she forced herself into a conversation I was having with an elderly voter who was unsure how to number the other boxes on your ballot paper. She had made it clear that she wished to vote for [redacted] and was not interested in any other candidates. This led to a short but nasty confrontation that should never have happened. I was also disturbed by the level of suppressed anger I saw among some voters who appeared to have a specific agenda, ie live sheep exports, wind farms and gun control. I feel that at least some of this was the result of deliberate mis-information.

The majority of the time I was unaware of the presence of any AEC officials. I never saw them offer assistance to disabled voters. More often there was an often-unseemly rush by polling volunteers to offer assistance sometimes with the intention of gaining a vote, perhaps. On the actual polling day, having put on a jacket to cover my tee-shirt, I approached an AEC official with a legitimate query from a voter and received a very hostile reception as he could apparently still see enough of my '[redacted] teeshirt to identify it. After I had zipped the jacket up and calmed him down, I was finally able to put the query to him. An unnecessary over-reaction considering I was, after all, offering my time free of charge to assist with the electoral process. I feel the electoral system is clearly in need of a complete overhaul and look forward to following this as it progresses.

J.K. TOR 1,2,3,6

My wife and I were alarmed and dismayed that the [redacted] were able to swamp both the pre-polls and polling day with their silly slogans and a seemingly limitless number of canvassers. I thought it quite intimidating for those voters who were still undecided. We were not ourselves particularly abused by anyone. I did not think there was any place for the so-called "keep the sheep" faction and informed them in terms they understood how much I despised them. We attended pre-poll at the same time as the [redacted] Candidate [redacted] and his supporters but we did not feel ill at ease, more sickened that [redacted] really do not care who the candidate is but are blinded by faith. I had good conversations with [redacted] volunteers but totally ignored [redacted] I am dismayed that some of the supporters have been subjected to any form of bad conduct. It is not what one might expect.

K.W. TOR 1

This section refers to the photos of the pamphlet entitled 'Ten Facts about [redacted]' contained within **Attachment 1.**

There were so many incidents of the misrepresentation of the [redacted] Her measured and considered response to local issues such as the live sheep trade and the possibility of wind turbines in the bay, for instance, was mistaken as indifference or an inability to form a policy. In fact, there were policy statements on her website. And very much apart from this, [redacted] was understandably reluctant to make policy statements about issues without all the details to hand. It is unfortunate that complex issues such as the ongoing viability of the live sheep trade, with so many contributing factors and possible solutions and alternatives, were reduced to a three-word slogan like 'Keep the Sheep.' As her supporters we begrudgingly had to accept what the democratic process has been reduced to.

There was a series of pamphlets that the [redacted] Party distributed during the campaign, all containing gross misrepresentations of the truth. However, what really shook us to the core was when the [redacted] Party produced an Australia Post distributed pamphlet entitled 'Ten Facts About [redacted]' during the weeks of pre-polling. [redacted] has never purported to being this fictitious political entity known as a [redacted] so the title itself is a gross misrepresentation. Going through the pamphlet, they are all statements that are either untrue, gross misrepresentations of the truth or misleading conjectures. The authorisation of political campaign material requires stringent regulation as soon as possible.

If nothing is done about truth in political campaigns, then we are inviting descension into aggressive free-for-alls that have no basis in truth.

J.K. TOR 4

In addition to our request for voter and volunteer experiences, our group held two workshops to discuss our grievances around the 2025 Federal Election, the terms of reference and the submission writing process. The following is a summary of the outcomes of those workshops.

Term of Reference - assessment and review of the purported increase in incidents of aggressive conduct, deliberate obstruction, and intimidating behaviour towards voters, political participants, volunteers, and Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) officials

- AEC authority requires greater presence, with reinforcement and acknowledgement that they are the governing body at the election booths.

Term of Reference - potential reform of safety and security arrangements, including consideration of the powers, processes, and capacity of the AEC to manage and address increasingly threatening or disruptive behaviour

- Are AEC officials given the resources and capacity to manage 'rogue behaviour?'
- Does there need to be more stringent policing of positioning of volunteers and the signs?
- There were endless complaints about the safety and annoyance factor of the number of volunteers and the number of signs at polling booths. Do we need to limit the number of volunteers per candidate and the number of signs allowed per candidate? This might also encourage more judicious selection and use of signs.

Term of Reference - the suitability and potential reform of measures to ensure universal voter access, including polling booth availability and location, early voting, remote polling, and postal voting arrangements

- The suitability of the Bunbury Sea Scouts Hall along Cobblestone Drive was a grave concern of many people. There were so many occasions when the elderly, disabled and distracted were almost hit by passing cars. The entrance was also inadequate and those having to line up on the walk/cycle way during busy times often obstructed walkers, runners, cyclists and people with prams.
- Regarding the postal vote, there is an issue with people going away before the candidate has been officially accepted. There is a lag between the postal vote going away and the ballot being finalised.

Term of Reference – the suitability of the current authorisation framework and requirements, having regard to the evolution of communication methods and technology

- The authorisation of signs and campaign material is an obvious area of concern that needs to be addressed fully and urgently for reasons of safety, integrity and environmental waste. At the very least, all signs and campaign material should be authorised by the candidate concerned. Then tackle the issue around truth.
- Moving forward, the issues around AI and social media are serious and extensive. The opportunity for manipulation with online voting apps, such as Build a Ballot, is concerning. Regarding AI, perhaps there needs to be legislation around the face and voice of a person (the candidate) being their property. Deep fake technology and the altering of images on social media is deeply disturbing anyway, but in the context of a political campaign the implications are dire.

Term of Reference – the implementation and operation of the electoral reform passed by the 47th Parliament, particularly regarding the use of money or capital in the most recent election

- There is nothing fair about the 'party machines' having seemingly endless amounts of 'cash to splash' at critical points in the campaign in at-risk electorates. Electorates are more vulnerable than ever to over-simplification of issues. Widely distributed signs with three-word slogans, widely distributed pamphlets with misrepresentation of the

truth, polling booths where people are transported into an electorate for days with all the associated costs. The enormous amount of money required to deliver this must be astounding.

- I ask the Joint Standing Committee, in what way does the Electoral Legislation Amendment (Electoral Reform) Bill 2024 affect the [redacted] candidate? Have you created a level playing field for all candidates?

Term of Reference – reforms to address the ongoing threats of interference in our electoral system, both foreign and domestic

- It would seem that the Plymouth Brethren had a significant role to play in the 2025 election.
- Face-less entities on social media, deep fake technology and the manipulation of online voting apps are all potential foreign and domestic threats.
- Social media algorithms which skew information presented to an individual increase the polarisation of our electorate and spills into real life

Term of Reference – the composition of the Parliament as a whole, including: the length of the parliamentary term; the potential for fixed terms; and the number of elected representatives relative to the growth in population and the electorate

Fixed terms would bring certainty to all those involved in planning and executing an election campaign

In conclusion, we thank you for this opportunity to share our concerns about how the election and political campaigns were conducted at the May 2025 Federal Election. Our experiences in Forrest, it seems, were emulated across Australia. Australians are incredibly fortunate to have an independent electoral body in the form of the AEC and our preferential voting system is unique and it makes every vote count. We need to keep these institutions strong and ensure that the AEC is properly funded and resourced. More than that, these issues being raised by communities across Australia, to the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters, need to be looked at closely. Without improvements to the current situation, Australian democracy is in jeopardy.

We would be willing to provide a witness to give evidence on behalf of the Forrest [redacted] volunteers, should there be a public enquiry held in Perth.

Yours sincerely

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]